

Are schools around the world becoming more similar over time?

The purpose of this essay is to discuss if school systems across the world are becoming more similar to one another overtime due to factors such as increased globalisation, with particular focus on the school systems in the United Kingdom and in Finland and how comparatively these systems have changed over time. It can be said that these school systems are becoming more similar overtime in terms of how they are trying to address certain global educational goals but on the other hand becoming very different in terms of how they approach educational practices, the inspection systems they use and how they teach their students.

It can be argued that increased globalisation has created similarities across school systems throughout the world overtime. This could be due to increased interconnectedness and communication through new technological advancements and global partnerships which establish educational goals such as Sustainable Development Goal number 4 (SDG-4), which helps promote positive educational ideals being put into practice across borders. SDG-4 are global education targets set with the United Nations to ensure quality education for all with goals such as providing free primary and secondary education for boys and girls equally and supplying equal access to early years education (The Global goals, 2024). Finland is known for being a highly progressive and effective educational system, with some even stating it is the “*best education system in the world*” (Leverage Edu, 2022). According to the Sustainable Development Report (2023) Finland has achieved all the SDG-4 goals for education, whereas in the UK it states that “*challenges remain*” (Sustainable Development Report, 2023) mainly in

terms of students' performance in science and the net enrollment rate which is not increasing as well as it should. Here we can see that Finland has found a way to create an education system that aligns with the global goals, which is why it is at the top of the sustainable development list for education.

However, schools across the globe could be becoming more different over time. One way that Finland's education system has changed to become more progressive and successful in teaching is that in the 1970's a new system known as 'Peruskoulu' was introduced as Finland's educational system (Morgan, 2014). Their previous system seemed more similar to the UK's current education system, in that by the age of eleven students would decide if they wanted to work in more academically aligned subjects or more practical subjects. In the UK students sit the 11+ exam which determines whether they will attend a grammar school or a mainstream state school. The previous Finnish education system was deemed to be highly unequal as students received varying levels of quality and availability of learning resources depending on the school they attended (Sahlberg, 2012 cited in Morgan, 2014). Today the 'Peruskoulu' system in Finland is beneficial to students in many ways, such as there only being one type of school (as opposed to separating private, technical and non-private schools) which would provide the same learning content regardless of the socioeconomic status of the students who attend the school. In the new system mandatory life counselling is also offered to all students to help them decide which educational path to choose as they approach secondary school. In Finland, today there is also much less focus on standardised testing compared to the UK where students sit the 11+, GCSEs and A-Levels (World economic forum, 2018). Finland's teachers instead choose to give students written, individual feedback and *"provide students with descriptions of their learning progress"*

(Darling and Hammond, 2011/12 cited in Morgan, 2014, p.454). If any assessment takes place, it is not used in competition with other students' grades but merely to see if the student understands the content being taught, and so doesn't go towards any major grade on their record.

In comparison, the UK school system seems to be more focused on standardised testing of students to assess educational quality and as a way for students to progress through their education. A study in the county of Kent in England conducted by Allen and Bartley (2017) on the social inequalities of the 11+ exam displayed that students who received free school meals (FSM), and were therefore of a lower socioeconomic status, were found to do worse in the reasoning part of the exam than students who didn't receive FSM. Although they stated that in Kent, schools are prohibited from coaching students in preparation for the test, many still choose to offer sessions to help boost students' maths and english skills which will inevitably help them with the test content. Therefore, reasoning skills were usually specifically taught to children in preparation for this part of the exam in certain schools but not in others. It was found that students who attended private primary schools in Kent did better in the reasoning part of the exam compared to Kent non-private schools and from primary schools outside of Kent. This clearly indicates that private schools, which by nature have more children from economically privileged backgrounds, are able to coach students in the reasoning part of the exam and ensure they are more prepared for this compared to some other non-private schools who may have more students attending from a lower socioeconomic background. In this way, we could speculate that the UK education system, even if just in some parts of the country as this study indicated, is currently highly unequal. As it mirrors Finland's previous system, it could be said that a solution to the inequality could be to adopt Finland's system of less focus on exam results and the pressure

of choosing a life path at an early age which could be beneficial for British school children in the longer term. This conveys that at the moment, the UK and Finland's education systems are becoming more dissimilar overtime, with Finland progressing through and finding solutions for the inequalities the children in their country faced before the 1970's by creating a new education system, while the UK continues to incorporate the 11+ exam into their system which is shown to produce major inequalities in learning outcomes.

Moreover, there are critiques regarding the similarity of schools in countries such as the UK and Finland as well as critiques of how globalisation has affected schools across the world. The development of the Program for international student assessment (PISA) (Grek, 2009) has affected education globally in various ways. Sahlberg (2016) notes that PISA has created more similarity in schools around the world by providing standardised testing and assessment so data from each country can be compared easily. While PISA has been praised for allowing global standards of skills sets to be established it has also been critiqued for streamlining school systems and creating categories of educational practice, when creativity and individualisation has been emphasised as important in terms of how students should learn and progress in their specific school contexts (Sahlberg, 2016). Critics argue that PISA establishes a set of what it deems as universally needed standards for educational success and the future of the worlds workforce, when in reality all cultures and countries have very different skills sets that fit into the context established in the specific place and country, and so generalising which skills are assessed cross culturally is misleading and potentially damaging to many societies (Zhao, 2020). Rautalin (2018) argues that in Finland, PISA establishes a skewed view of how the school system functions, overemphasising its effectiveness and not exploring the negative aspects of the

system. While Finland's education system is clearly remarkable, Rautalin (2018) discusses how PISA has ignored the issue of mental health and social interactions between pupils, the education of which is lacking in Finnish schools. PISA does not evaluate mental health and social interactions in school pupils, just reading, maths and science skills (Araújo et al., 2021). These unmeasured aspects can be argued to be essential skills too and equally needed for students in schools. This means that PISA produces a distorted view of Finland's education system by not accounting for differences within the country itself as well as measuring only certain specialist skills which may not hold the same value across different countries and cultures.

In addition, another difference between school systems worldwide is how schools are inspected and how teachers' standards of educating are assessed. A contrast between the UK and Finland's education systems is that since 1992 the UK uses Ofsted (Office for Standards in Education, Children's Services and Skills) inspections to rate a schools' quality (Rosenthal, 2004), while Finland doesn't have any country wide inspection system within schools, only in school self-evaluations (Webb et al., 1998). In the UK, the use of Ofsted inspections in schools has been both praised and critiqued. Perryman et al. (2023) finds that Ofsted inspections are useful in some ways as they provide reassurance to the government, parents and educators that the school is providing quality education for students and keeping children safe. However, overwhelmingly there have been critiques of the Ofsted system. Case et al. (2000) reported that levels of stress in teachers were noted to elevate when an Ofsted inspection was announced which decreased productivity in the classroom as teachers became more focused on the work they needed to do to ensure the inspection went well. Moreover, Ofsted inspections seemed not to change schools' performance levels in any meaningful way, and it has been noted that *“1 year after inspection, it*

(inspections) has had no lasting impact on what they (teachers) do in the classroom.” (Case et al., 2000, p.1), conveying that the inspections seem to be superficial and simply a performative exercise which teachers are put through that doesn't result in any real change for schools.

However, in Finland schools and teachers are trusted to provide quality education to students because of both the high-quality training the Finnish teachers receive as well as studies having been conducted about the school system internationally, which suggest it works well and provides excellent education to its students (Andere M., 2014). Therefore, the Finnish government has sufficient evidence to believe there is no need to rank or compare schools or assess the quality of individual teachers. While there is some internal evaluation in Finnish schools, the aim is to allow schools to develop further, not to control or penalise them and therefore the result of any evaluation that takes place will never lead to cuts in funding for the school or any comparisons with other schools (Linnakylä et al., 2010)

Overall, in many ways school systems around the world are becoming more similar over time due to factors of globalisation such as the influence of PISA. While some dissimilarity is present in the comparison of the UK and Finland's educational systems such as the differences in testing of students, inspections of schools and the structure of a child's educational journey, this is one of the more extreme cases of vast differences between systems. The idea of schools becoming more similar has some negative consequences in that a sense of a unique style of education and some creativity may be compromised in favour of more rigidity through standardised practices, as well as the pressure placed on educators to ensure the best quality of education for all students, which may be hard to achieve. However, the benefits of the effect of globalisation and interconnectedness amongst schools is also a factor as schools are able to see where the best

practices of education are and therefore potentially improve their own system in accordance with this. Therefore, we can say that in the future schools may continue to become similar to each other because of increased globalisation, comparison and communication amongst schools around the world.

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